

Smothered mates



11...Qg1+ 12. Rxcg1 Nf2#

12...Nf2# Mate: knight on f2 gives check; White has no legal reply.

CHECKPOINT

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A familiar pattern is insufficient if the knight can be captured. Verify protection and every legal king move.

A knight can check a king surrounded by its own pieces. Those pieces become a cage because a knight check cannot be blocked.

Trace the knight's route to the checking square and identify the enemy pieces that deny the king its escape squares.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: knight on h8 and bishop on c4. Check for tactical protection.